The Fern on the Return Slip

Lark & Nib's Treasure Quest · Season 4, Episode 4

Two papers bore a fern emblem. Nib held them side by side as if matching pictures settled everything. One was a current borrowing slip. The other was an old direction note. Sea rested on the cart while Lark checked what each page was for.

“Two ferns, one book,” Nib reported anxiously. “One current borrowing slip,” Lark replied carefully.

Lark opened an earlier journal page on a flat, dry surface. Nib steadied its lower corner. One familiar word waited for another look.

“Try our earlier word before we start,” Lark invited gently. “You can sound it out or ask for help.”

> **cart**

“In fern, er works as a vowel spelling,” Lark modeled clearly. “Read her, fern, and stern using the sound in our ordinary speech. Knowing fern doesn't tell us which paper is current; the borrower picture and date space give different information.”

“Join the parts and check the whole meaning,” Lark invited gently. “You can hear a part again whenever you want.”

On a little practice strip, you could try her, fern, stern. Lark supplied unfamiliar story names herself. Nib waited while you looked right through each word.

“Read fern, then compare the two slips,” Lark invited gently. “Which one records this borrower and today's loan?”

A short passage stayed in view. Lark paired each needed capital with its lowercase form and familiar sound before you began, leaving the sentence meanings for you to discover.

“Read the sentences in order,” Lark invited gently. “Let your finger follow if it helps. When you are ready, use the words to answer our question.”

> **A fern is by a cart. Her cap is on a shelf.**

“Where is the cap?” Lark asked gently. “Which sentence describes the plant instead?”

Lark kept the passage open so you could point to the part that helped. Nib listened before adding the picture.

Lark supplied the date and place names. The current slip matched the waiting borrower's shelf. Nib placed Sea there, and Lark entered the loan once in the record. The old direction note stayed out of the lending ledger. One book was lent; Moon, Train, and Phone remained aboard for their later stops.

“Let's keep a written clue,” Lark suggested warmly. “Write fern beside our picture. You can look at the example, follow it first, or try your own version. Then reread what you made.”

The Commons shelf kept Sea for its agreed loan time. Your boat turned toward the next bend, where a rope route passed too close to a bird's fixed perch.